The History of Caistor Grammar School

The Caistorians' Association is the alumni organisation for Caistor Grammar School. We aim to preserve the history of the School, and to make it available to all who may be interested.

The following is based on a talk given to the Caistor Civic Society.

From Foundation to 1899:
Andrew Hunter, pupil 1963 – 1970

1900 to the present:
Tom Hunter, pupil 1964 – 1969

The School buildings and facilities:
Eddie Cook, Deputy Head 1996 – 2016

Boarding at Caistor Grammar School:
Graeme Kemshall, boarder 1956 – 1963

The Curriculum:
Polly Baxter

From Foundation to 1899 by Andrew Hunter
Part 1

Today Caistor Grammar School is approaching the 400th anniversary of its foundation in 1630. Much of what we know of its early history comes from the preparations made for the school's 300th Anniversary. The Rev T.G. Dixon, chairman of the governors, and Mr H.E.J. Coxon, headmaster, finding that the school had no proper records of its own history, set about remedying the situation. They found enough to fill a book, and fortunately, they did fill a book, which we now have.

But to begin at the beginning, we have to go much further back than the reign of King Charles I, during which the school was founded. We have to go back more than 700 hundred years, King Edward I, who reigned from 1272 to 1307

During his reign Edward I granted lands in South Kelsey to one Sir Robert Hansard, for his part in the Scottish Wars.

The Hansards were at South Kelsey until the middle of the 1500's, when the male line ended with William Hansard who had no heir other than his daughter Elisabeth.

This Elisabeth Hansard married Sir Francis Ayscough, who became owner of South Kelsey Hall. And not only did Sir Francis gain the Hall, he also became patron of the Rectory of St. Nicholas, South Kelsey.

In 1603 the living of St. Nicholas became vacant. Sir Edward Ayscough, who had inherited from Sir Francis, his father, used his patronage to appoint as rector Francis Rawlinson.

Francis Rawlinson was a local man, having been born in Market Rasen in 1564 and educated there (at a school which stood between the railway bridge and Oxford Street) and then at Clare College of Cambridge University. His position before South Kelsey was Vicar of Middle Rasen Drax, where he had been since 1589, shortly after his ordination.

Middle Rasen, was, like South Kelsey, a village with two churches. Middle Rasen Drax has, like St. Nicholas South Kelsey, disappeared.

CGS History Part 2

Francis Rawlinson spent more than 27 years as Rector of St. Nicholas. In those 27 years he married twice, both times to widows, and acquired in so doing 9 step-children, but had no children of his own. Also in those 27 years Sir Edward Ayscough died, and was succeeded by his grandson, also Sir Edward. The second Sir Edward was also MP for Lincoln.

This brings us to the close of the year 1630

On the 29th December, Francis Rawlinson, signed his will, and later that day, died.

NB. The will is a very long document, and must have been some time in preparation, but it was the practice, at least for some, to delay putting their signature to their will until death was imminent.

The relevant parts of the will are:
1. "I give commit and bequeath into the hands of the Right Worshipful Sir Edward Ayscough, Knight, the sum of four hundred pounds"
2. "for and towards the foundation and maintenance of a free Grammar School to continue forever in the market town of Caistor in the County of Lincoln if the inhabitants of that town shall and will at their own proper cost erect and build up in some convenient place in that town a House" … "to be the Schoolhouse within two years after my decease.
3. "My will and desire is that the said Sir Edward Ayscough and his heirs for ever be Feoffees in trust and Patrons of the said school to elect a fit and sufficient school master as often as the place shall be void" And "that the Town of Caistor and whatsoever Towns besides that shall send shall be free to have the children taught in the said school"

So there you have it. Rawlinson has founded the school and Ayscough is to be the patron.

CGS History Part 3

But, just as we presume Sir Edward Ayscough to have been making the arrangements…

William Hansard of Biscathorpe died - in December 1631.
And he made a similar provision…
"My will and mind is that there shall be erected and built a convenient schoolhouse for the instructing of youth in good literature within or near the town of Caistor in the county of Lincoln, within 3 years of my decease.
Also I give and bequeath to the head schoolmaster the yearly stipend of thirty pounds and unto the usher or under schoolmaster the yearly stipend of fifteen pounds…"

Hansard's will is dated 18th March 1628, but as he did not die until 1631 then Rawlinson, whose will is dated later but death earlier, got there first.

Hansard's will continues:
"A book shall be kept at Caistor Church with a copy of will and ordinances etc., etc."
"I appoint my executors to give and pay out towards the building of the intended schoolhouse at Caistor the sum of two hundred and fifty pounds."

The Hansards of Biscathorpe were related to the Hansards of South Kelsey, though the exact connection is not clear. They used the same coat of arms, though they cannot be direct heirs, otherwise they would have held onto South Kelsey Hall. William of Biscathorpe, was like William of South Kelsey, the last male of his line of Hansards. He left as heirs 2 daughters.

Biscathorpe is - or was - little remains except the Hall - a village just north of Donnington on Bain. The nearest towns are thus Louth, Market Rasen and Wragby. Louth and Market Rasen already had schools, and William Hansard also left money to found a school at Wragby (it was built, in 1636, but fell into disrepair, and was pulled down in 1775).

CGS History Part 4

Now we turn to the question of who built the school.

And as we look for the answer to that question we begin to wish that Rawlinson had made another provision of his will. He had provided the money for school master and appointed a patron to see that it was done, though leaving the building of the school to the inhabitants of Caistor.

But what he did not do was require anyone to keep records of what they had done.

It was not Rawlinson who built the school. Nothing happened until he died. The date in the school building is 1631. It ought to have been the inhabitants of Caistor. It might have been William Hansard - who certainly left money for it - though as he was not an inhabitant of Caistor, that would conflict with a requirement of Rawlinson's will.

The only official view of what happened came in 1837. Parliament had ordered an enquiry into the Charities of England and Wales, and appointed commissioners for that purpose.

1837 was, of course, more than 200 years after the founding of the school. The commissioners could not be certain, but wrote
"… it is not improbable that the schoolhouse at Caistor was built with the £250 given for that purpose by Hansard or part thereof…".



Figure 1. The original building as it looks today. The Old Hall, was built in c1631. Divided into 2 rooms – one for the Headmaster to teach in and one for the Usher.

For nearly 300 years the school appears to have kept no surviving records, nor taken any interest in its own history.

Most of what is known comes from records Colleges of Cambridge University, who recorded the earlier education of their graduates.

The earliest of these is: Robert Harrison, son of Robert Harrison, born Belshford, Lincs. School Caistor, under Mr Metcalf 4 years, under Mr Welfit 2 years, admitted pensioner Christ's College, under Mr Gell 27th July, 1640, aged 16.

Taking 6 years from 1640 makes Mr Metcalf headmaster on 1634 (which almost certainly makes him the first) and Mr Welfit Headmaster in 1638.

It is possible to identify William Metcalf as the son of Sir Francis Metcalf of Louth Park, by Jane, daughter of Sir Edward Ayscough of South Kelsey (which makes William a first cousin of Sir Edward Ayscough, patron - and may explain how he got the job).



CGS History Part 5

And similarly, for the next 200 years of so. Many, but not all, the headmasters were also Vicars of Caistor.

The Ayscoughs were patrons for several generations, until the last of the family, Isabel Ayscough, married Matthew Boucherett of North Willingham about 1710. Their son was Ayscough Boucherett who became Patron, and who was succeeded by his son, also Ayscough Boucherett in 1789, and he by his son, also Ayscough Boucherett, in 1815.

In 1818 Nicholas Carlisle published a "Concise description of the endowed Grammar Schools of England and Wales", in which he stated regarding Caistor "the present number of boys and girls in the school is between 30 and 40".

In 1834 there was a series of letters to the Stamford Mercury (which would have been the "local" newspaper of the day) about the appointment of Mr John Bell as headmaster.

Then there was Charity Commissioners enquiry of 1837

In 1838 an advert in the Stamford Mercury "W.Ellis, LLD, headmaster of Caistor Grammar School, begs leave to intimate that his arrangements for the reception of pupils as boarders are now completed…"

Then, in 1853, a court case between the Charity Commissioners and Mr Ayscough Boucherett about who had the right to appoint a new headmaster. (Boucherett had appointed Mr Anthony Bower, the Charity Commissioners alleged that Ayscough Boucherett was not - at least in law - the heir of Sir Edward Ayscough). The commissioners lost the case.

Then, in 1871, the arrival of Henry Newbolt as a pupil (Bower was still headmaster, and had earlier been Newbolt's father's tutor at Cambridge).
Newbolt wrote a fictional account of his early life entitled "The Twymans" in which Percy Twyman is sent to school at Casterby. In the 1960's reality imitated fiction in that the house where Newbolt had boarded was given the name "Casterby House".

The last Ayscough Boucherett died in 1857, and was succeeded by his son Henry Robert, who died unmarried in 1877. His heirs were his sisters Louisa and Emelia, who surrendered their position as Patrons in 1885 under a scheme framed under the Endowed Schools Acts (of 1869, 1873 and 1874).

The school was from that time run by Governors, who appointed new headmasters in 1894, 1896, and 1904.

All these headmasters - and several before them - had suffered from the limits of Rawlinson's will. The school was free, so however many pupils it had there were no funds to expand the buildings or increase the staff. And the salary of the headmaster was fixed.

Around the beginning of the 20th Century various Acts of Parliament made the administration of education the responsibility of local government. The relevant authority for Caistor was Lindsey County Council.

Acts of Parliament had also provided that pupils from elementary schools who passed the relevant examination were awarded scholarships - which meant that the education authority paid a grammar school to educate those pupils. (It was allowable for parents of children who did not pass to pay the grammar school to educate their children).

But in the opinion of Lindsey County Council Caistor Grammar School was "not recognised as efficient". This meant that they would not pay Caistor to educate scholarship pupils, those from Caistor had to go to Market Rasen for the grammar school education. In 1904 Caistor had only had 7 pupils, though the headmaster appointed in 1904 brought about a dozen boarders.

In 1905 a committee of Lindsey County Council visited the school and enquired into its status and finances. They made various recommendations, among which was that the school should admit girls. As a result of the school adopting these recommendations it was recognised as efficient in 1908.

There is a question as to why the education authority should have bothered with a school that had only 7 pupils. Here I think girls are the answer. The school in Market Rasen - De Aston - was a boys only grammar school. and the education authority has a responsibility laid on it my national government - to educate both boys and girls. And they have already recognised De Aston as efficient, while allowing it to be boys only, so they need Caistor to get them out of a problem.

1900 to the present by Tom Hunter

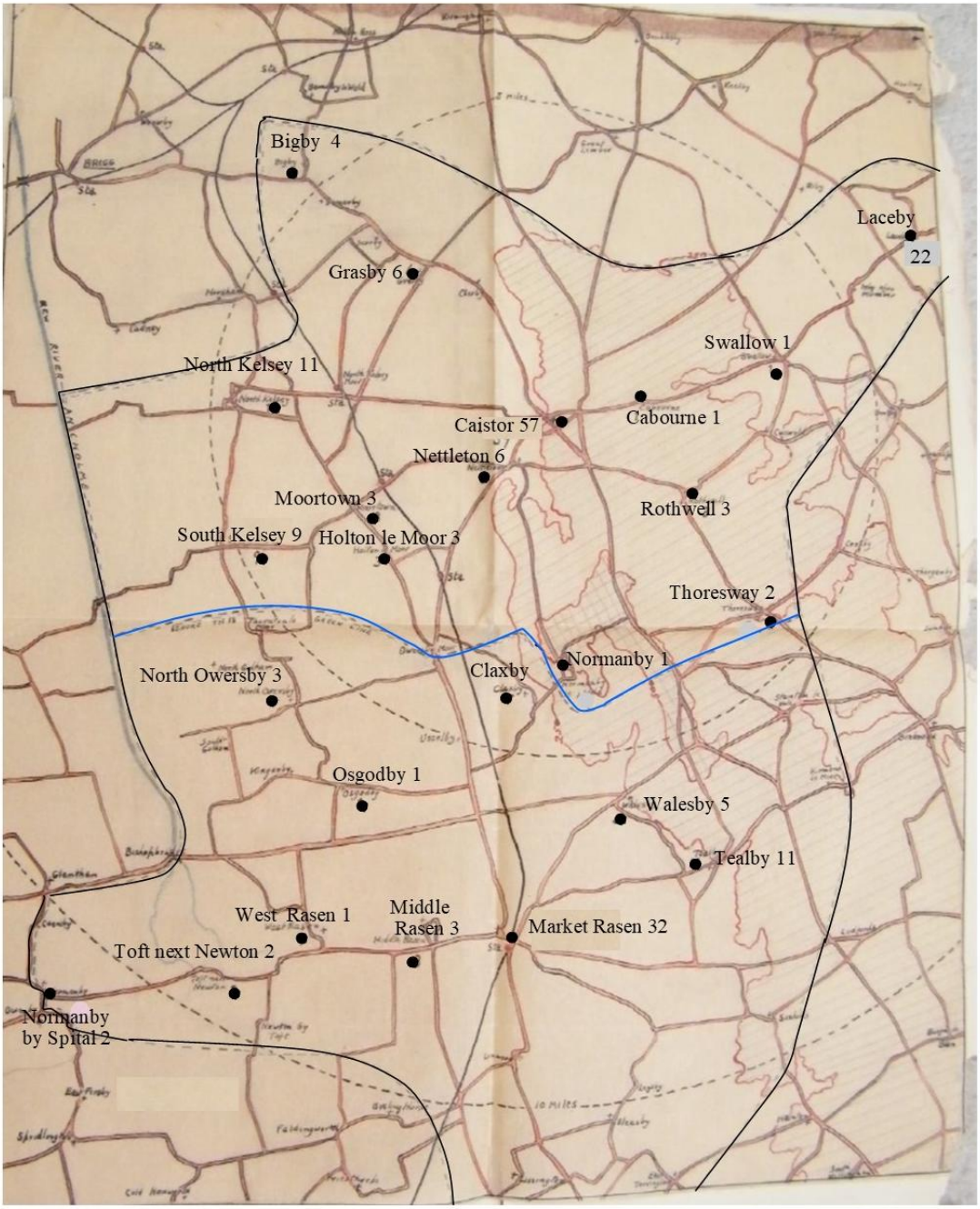
At the beginning of the 20th century Arthur Glover was Headmaster at CGS.
The 1902 Education Act established Local Education Authorities to replace the School Boards, and created the system of Primary and Secondary Education. It brought all schools into a common system of financial support from the rates. Under this Act, the Lindsey County Council LEA recognised De Aston School in Market Rasen as the Grammar School for the area, despite the fact that De Aston was a boys only school.

At the time Caistor Grammar School was in a poor situation. In 1904, when Arthur Brooke became Headmaster, (The 4th new Headmaster in 20 years), there were only 7 pupils and the finances were in a desperate state. It was regarded at being too small to be worthy of LEA support. However the LEA had placed themselves in a difficult position, because they were obliged to provide a grammar school education for girls. The School inspector's report of 1906 makes interesting reading:

'*My previous estimate of the chances of the School was based upon its somewhat hopeless outlook. The Headmaster was applying for other posts. Local feeling about the School is apathetic, and the governing body takes a gloomy view of the future.'*
The report then goes on to give a very positive view of the prospects for the school.
'The Headmaster is Efficient and Keen, one permanent assistant, a fair teacher and visiting masters for Drill and Art'
'The new docks, building at Immingham, and the proposed ironstone works at Nettleton may also have some effect on the future of the school'.
When Caistor was practically moribund, only 2 Caistor and Nettleton boys went to Market Rasen, the rest went to no secondary school at all'

The report concludes *'no competing school can claim to fill the requirement with equal or better effect'* Reading between the lines one cannot help thinking that the report had been written with an eye on the LEA's predicament, and that the only way out was to justify the case for supporting CGS.
The result of this was that in 1908 CGS was recognised as efficient by the LEA and became established in the mainstream of secondary education. As such it was allocated a defined catchment area was that it was almost twice the size for girls as it was for boys, because it included most of De Aston's catchment area, but only for girls.

Caistor Grammar School Catchment Area - December 1960



The black line is the fullest extent of the catchment area, this applies to girls. The boys' catchment area is limited in the south by the blue line. The reason for the difference is that De Aston in Market Rasen was at that time a boys' only grammar school.
Two parts of the catchment area are beyond the limit of the map. Top right is Laceby, only the remainder of that parish is missing. At the bottom of the map some villages, as yet unidentified, are omitted.
The total number of pupils is 194, but a photograph of the school's pupils dated October 1960 shows 216, so that map is incomplete in that respect. The 57 pupils from Caistor are from both town and boarders.
If anyone is able to put names to some of the numbers on the map please let the Editor know.

Although the support from the LEA ensured that GCS's finances were not the Headmaster's responsibility to the extent that they had been, the school's income was still closely tied to the number of pupils on the books.

By 1910 the school roll was 46. When Henry Coxon took over as Headmaster in 1913, he set about promoting the school and attracting additional pupils. Several people have told anecdotes about Mr. Coxon going around the area in his pony and trap, visiting local primary and secondary schools to recruit additional pupils. He was successful in his efforts, there were 60 pupils in 1914, by 1930 this had risen to 135.
The number of pupils remained around this level until after WW2. The 1944 Education Act, known as the Butler Act, changed the admission criteria for secondary education. Before the Act, admission to Grammar School was by passing the Scholarship exam, in which case the LEA would pay the fees, or for those who did not pass the Scholarship, the parents could pay the school directly. The 1944 Act allowed for those who passed the Scholarship (11 plus) to be funded by the LEA as before, and those who did not were given a place at a Secondary Modern School. The option for parents to pay for a place at Grammar School was removed, which may have slightly reduced to total numbers at the school. The 1944 Act also brought to an end the Kindergarten that the school had run for 9 and 10 year olds. The Kindergarten gave a good education, but did not remove the requirement to pass the scholarship exam to be admitted to the main school.
1945 saw changes. Mr Coxon retired, and was replaced by Mr Robert Capper, an ex RAF officer. In the next few years, the capacity of the school was increased by the construction of several pre-fabricated buildings.

Mr Capper died in office in February 1957, and was succeeded by Mr K.G. Michel who took office at Easter that year. When interviewed for the post Mr Michel has been informed of plans to completely rebuild the school on a new site. At this point there were 224 pupils at the school.

Hardly had Mr Michel taken office than the County Council announced a plan to close the school. We believe that this was prompted by a request by parents of Market Rasen who wished their daughters to be educated in the town as their sons were. There were about 60 girls from the area.

The County Council reasoned that if the Market Rasen girls were taken away from Caistor then the rest of the pupils could be reallocated to De Aston, Brigg or Clee, and there would be no need for Caistor Grammar School at all.
There was a walk to protest about this, organized by the senior pupils, (and a very impressive document prepared by Mr A. G. Barr, Clerk to the RDC, setting out why the school should not be closed). The walk took place overnight on February 18th & 19th 1960, through a snowstorm. At least one of those taking part was a Market Rasen girl.

As a result, the County Council had second thoughts. The Closure plan was referred back, reconsidered, and finally, in May 1964 abandoned. Instead Caistor was to have a new Boarding House (and De Aston was to make preparations to admit girls).

The new Boarding House, Lindsey House, with an accommodation for 50 boarders, opened in May, 1967.

The next major change came in 1972, when De Aston School became coeducational, an event that significantly changed the catchment area. The girls from the Market Rasen area who were already at CGS did not transfer, but no new girls from Market Rasen went to Caistor. This would have had the effect over the next 5 to 7 years of reducing the school's roll by about 30%. In 1974 the local Government reform created Humberside as a local authority, taking in the northern part of Lincolnshire. The village of Laceby, that had been sending about 80 pupils to Caistor, was in Humberside. The existing pupils did not transfer, but no new pupils from Laceby went to Caistor. This was compensated to some extent by Binbrook and Keelby being brought into Caistor's catchment area.
When Mr Michel retired at Easter 1981 (after exactly 24 years as head) the number of pupils was 327.

Mr Michel's replacement as Headmaster was Trevor Foulkes. There was a considerable amount of reconstruction on the site in the 1980's, most of the prefabricated buildings were removed, the present day Manning building was constructed, as was the Science and Technology block. Grove house was demolished, as it was suffering from subsidence and becoming unsafe.

The 1988 Education Act introduced the right of Parental Choice into the school system. Previously, the LEA had determined which schools pupils went to. The effect of the 1988 Act was to allow parents to choose which school there children should attend. Admission was changed from 11 plus to the school's own entrance exam.
The school ceased to take boarders after 1995.

Trevor Foulkes retired in 1996, his replacement was Roger Hale, who had been deputy head. The number of pupils at this point was around 560.
Roger remained Head until his retirement in 2016. During his time, the school was recognised as a Sports College in 2005 and achieved Academy Status in 2010. Admission was changed from 11 plus to the school's own entrance exam. Further buildings were constructed, Lindsey House was converted to classrooms, and the Olympic Torch building was constructed next to it in 2012.

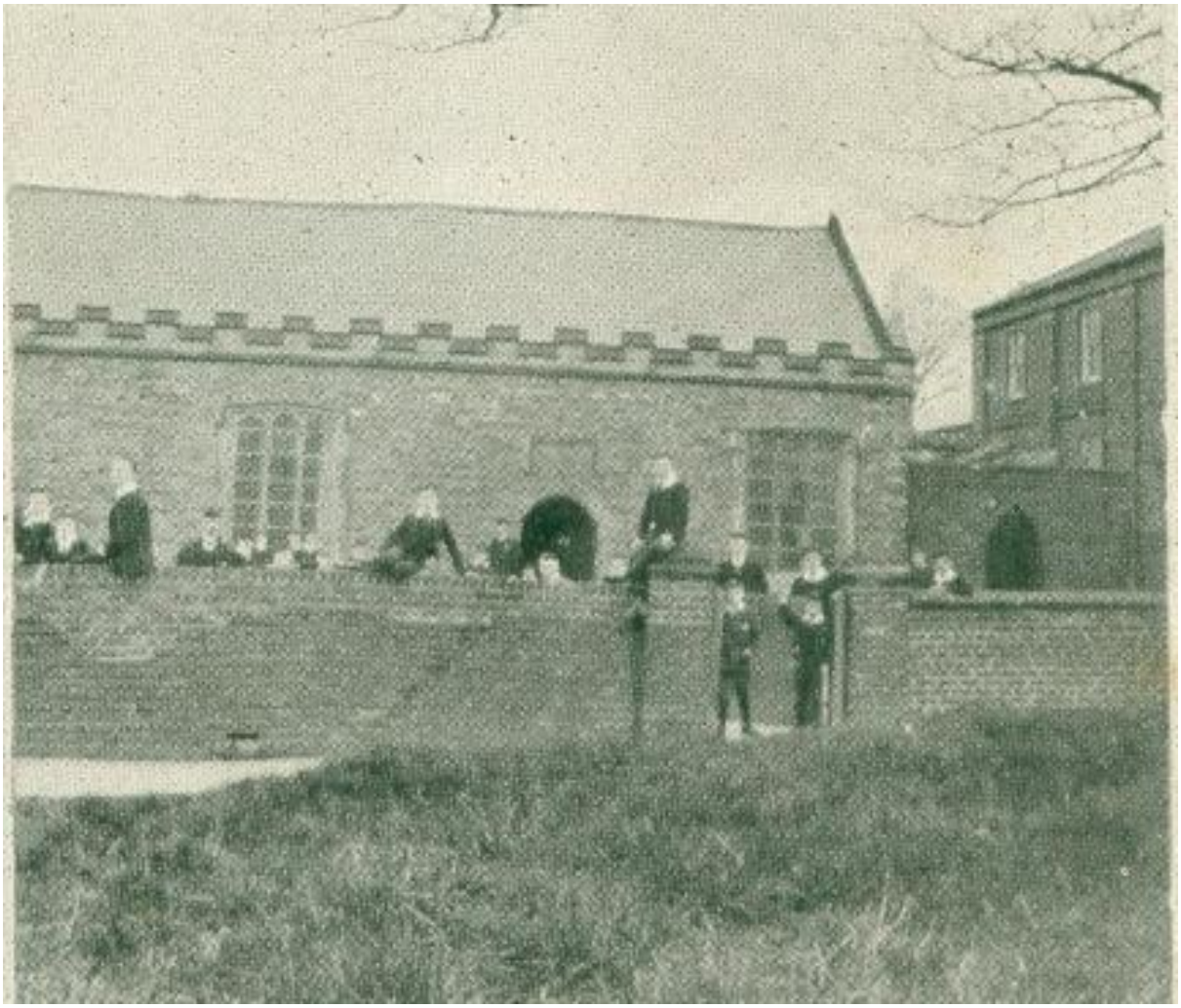
The current school role in about 650. The School has topped the Sunday Times 'Best State School in the East Midlands' list and has been rated as 'Outstanding' by Ofsted in each of the inspections between 1995 and 2016. A fitting tribute to the hard work and determination of those who have ensured to continuation and success of the school for the past 390 years.
Roger Hale's replacement was Alistair Hopkins with Shona Buck being appointed as the first female Headteacher in 2021. The School continues to maintain high standards, ensuring that the school lives up to its motto, 'Ever to Excel'

The School buildings and facilities by Eddie Cook,

In 1837 repairs were needed and the parapet was added on the south side.



As the 20th century began the school was still based in the same building,



although by 1931 a major renovation was required.



The only other significant CGS building in the 18th and 19th centuries was Grove House. A lovely building which stood at the top of the terraces but was sadly demolished in the late 1980s due to subsidence.

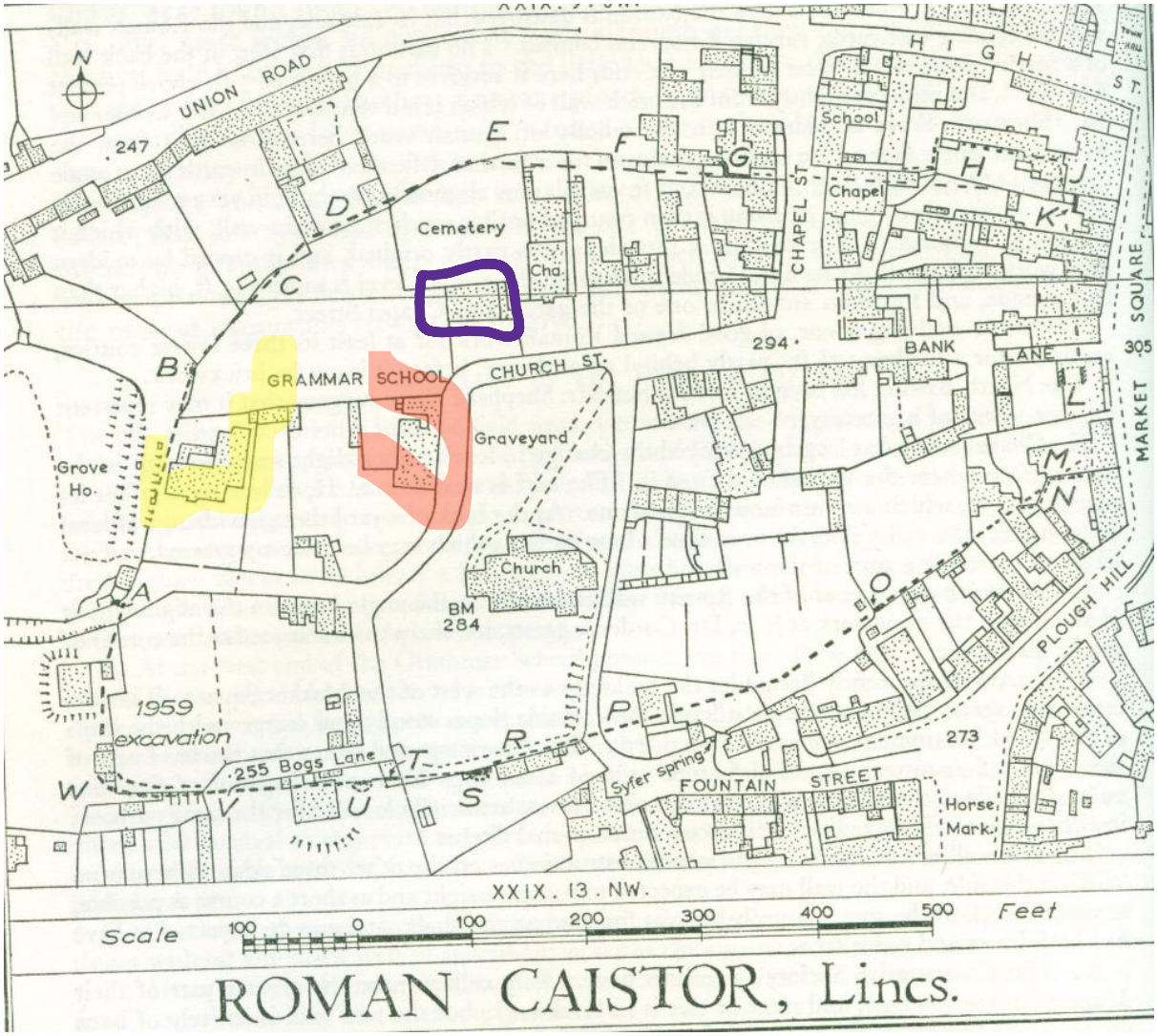


The Grove House site was bought by Headmaster Christopher Cave in 1775. Upto 1798 Cave built and used the building as a boarding house – BUT by 1805 Grove House had been sold and it wasn't until 1853 that Headmaster, Rev. Anthony Bower, had bought Grove House and made it a boarding house for CGS pupils again.



Bower resigned in 1884 but probably lived in the house until 1887. Alfred Varlow bought Grove House in 1887 and it wasn't until 1919 it again became a CGS boarding house and was bought by the grammar school governors in 1921.





The old map (it shows North Kelsey Rd as Union Road) shows Grove House (yellow). It was demolished around 1987 as its location at the top of the terraces had created very significant

movement and subsidence. The Old Hall marked by a blue line and School House, (in 1967 renamed Casterby) is marked in red. (Apologies for the inaccurate placing of the colours!)
In 1893 the Head, Robert Thomas, had bought ‘the southern end’ of what is now known as Casterby House (previously School House) on Church Street.
The postcard below is looking north.

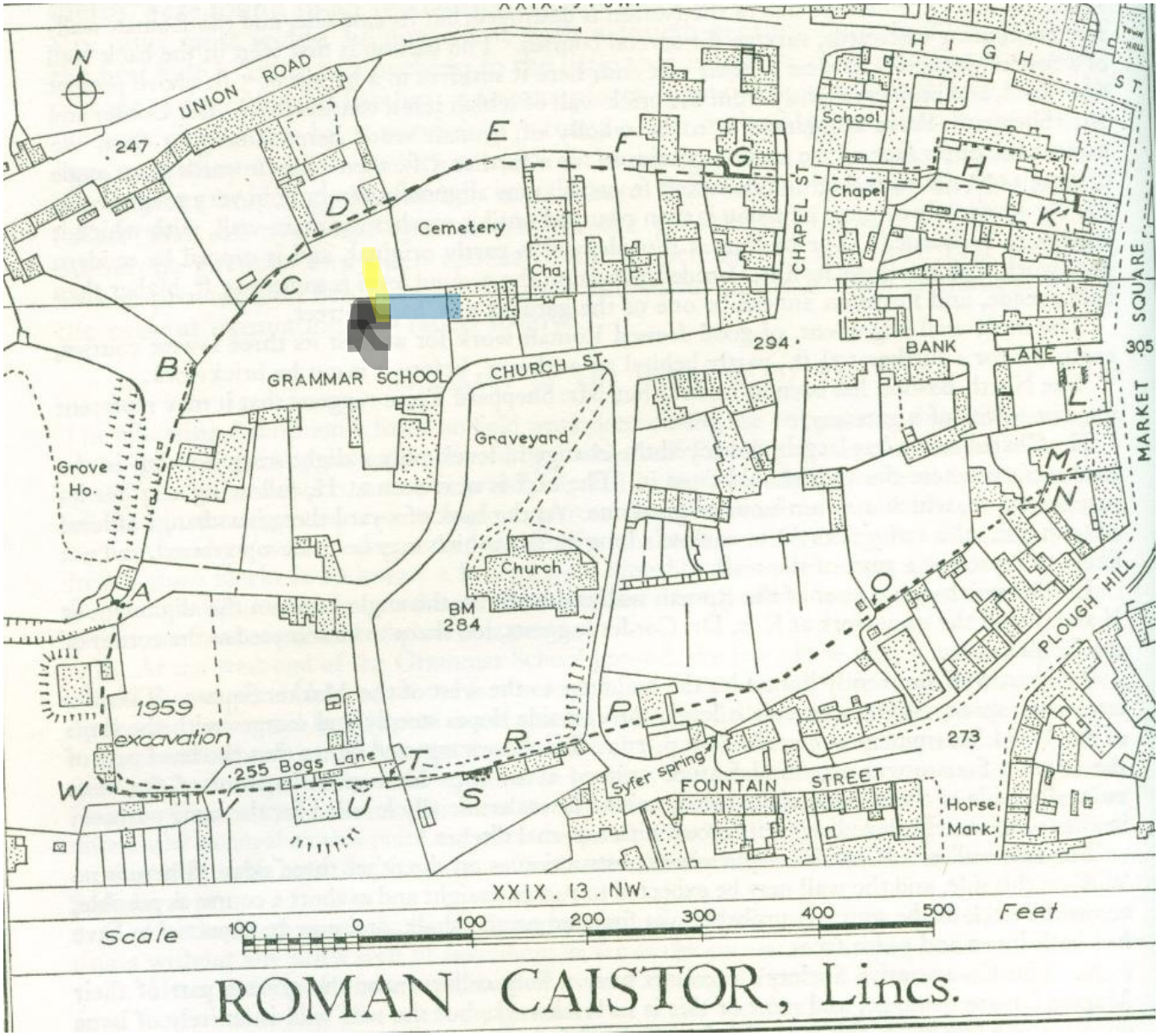




Casterby (note the blue plaque) looks more attractive today and is now used as the 6th form centre.

In 1909 two additional rooms were built (**Blue on next slide**). One was the school library in 1964. They were later knocked through to make one science lab.

With Henry Coxon appointed as Head in 1913 the school expanded and continued to thrive. In 1914 a new laboratory was built (**Black),** which became the school kitchen in the 1960s, then a language lab and is now the RE room.



Around this time the governors secured a lease from Lord Tennyson, on the garden grounds adjoining the school premises with the option of purchase. The girls' toilets were probably built around the same time (**Yellow).**

The 1909 and 1914 buildings look like this now.



In 1914 the northern end of School House was bought and a playing field – we assume it is the present school playing field on Navigation Lane. (Note the church tower)



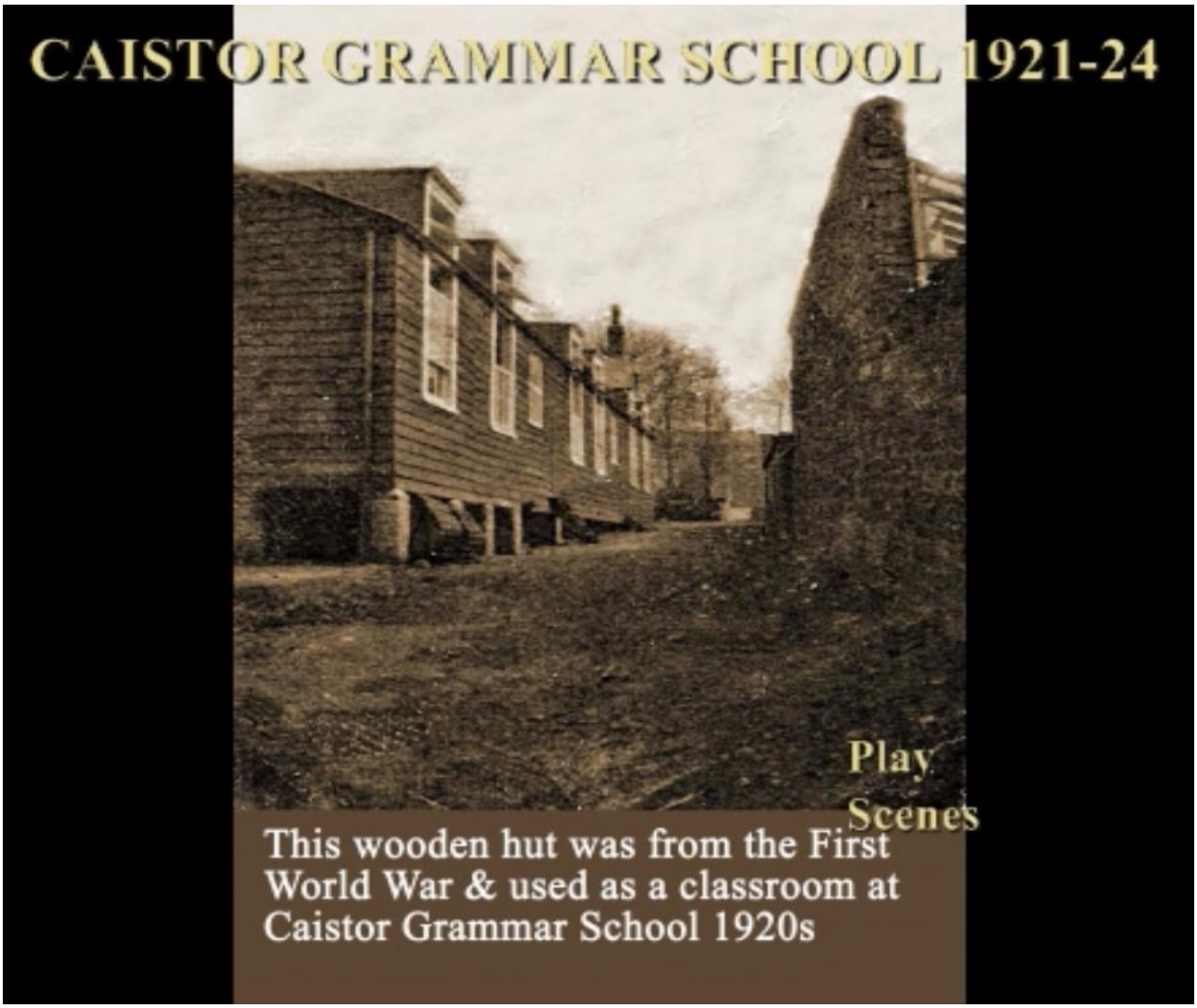
The field looks a little better now, with levelled pitches, an all weather surface and a lovely pavilion, built with the help of donations from Old Caistorians and opened in 2005 by Trevor Brooking – the England football legend.







A large army hut was acquired in 1920 to provide 3 more classrooms.



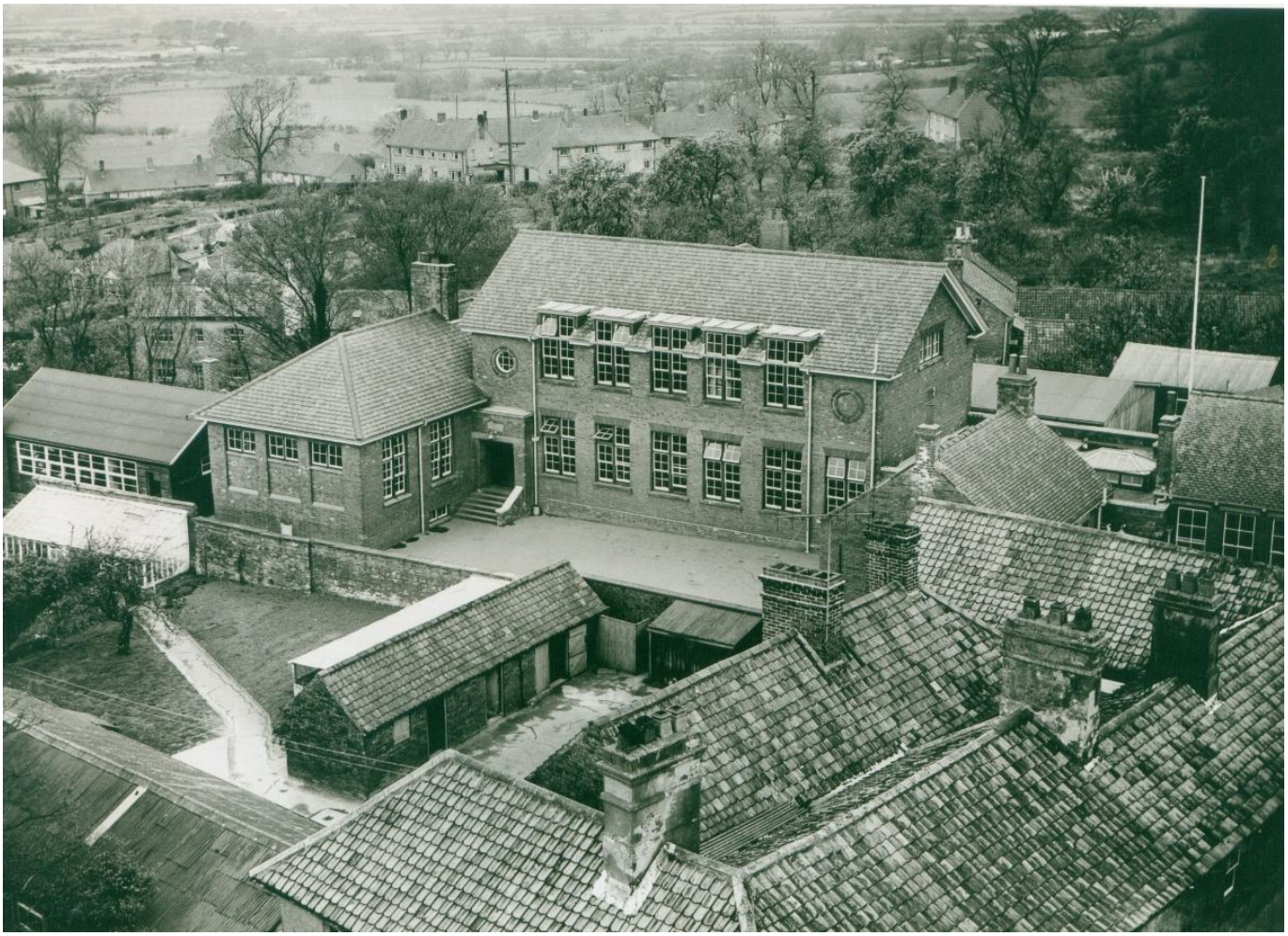
In 1921 another boarding house was acquired, which we assume to be Red House at the junction of Back Lane, Chapel Street and Church Street.



Although used in the prospectuses the dormitories didn't look that welcoming. This is a room in Grove House.



Mr Coxon had been Head for 17 years in 1930 when the 300th anniversary of the School was marked by the opening of the new Main building. This photo taken, from the church tower, dates from about 1960. Casterby's double roof is in the foreground as well as the bike sheds. Some of the prefab buildings from the 1950s can also be seen.



The facilities were good. This shows ‘Pop’ Linsells chemistry lab in the 1980s.



And previously in 1950. This room is now the staffroom.



So the view down Church street towards the school in the 1930s, 40s, 50s, etc is fairly similar to the scene we see today.





Temporary buildings have been a feature of CGS during the 20th and 21st centuries.



This one housed the boarders dining room.



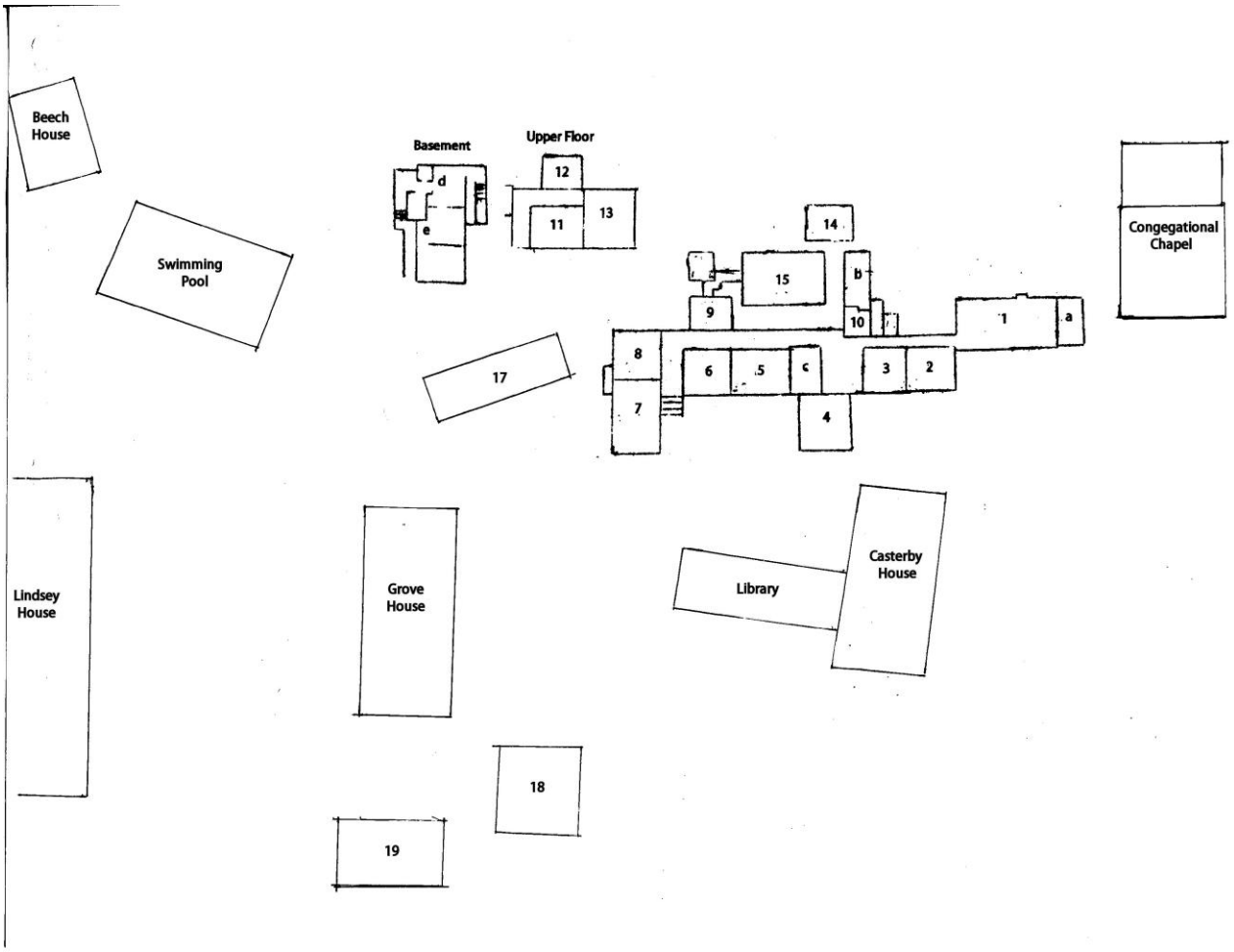
This prefab dates from around 1961, sometimes called ‘the New Spooner’ it was used for music but for the last 25 years has been a history room. (Since giving this talk the two mobies [known as P2 and P3] have been removed. Grove Court, a new language block has been built on the bottom tennis court, providing 3 additional teaching rooms as well as a social space and office.



It was moved to be next to Rm 19, now P3, was the needlework room, thought to date from 1965.



Both of these portacabins are shown on a sketch map drawn by Paul Reddington in 1973.



Paul's map is not to scale but shows the School buildings in the early 1970s. A number of which were relatively new. No portacabins exist on the site today.
This one was placed for a while on what was at one time called the Boys' Yard but is now known as the Old Yard, in front of the Old Hall.



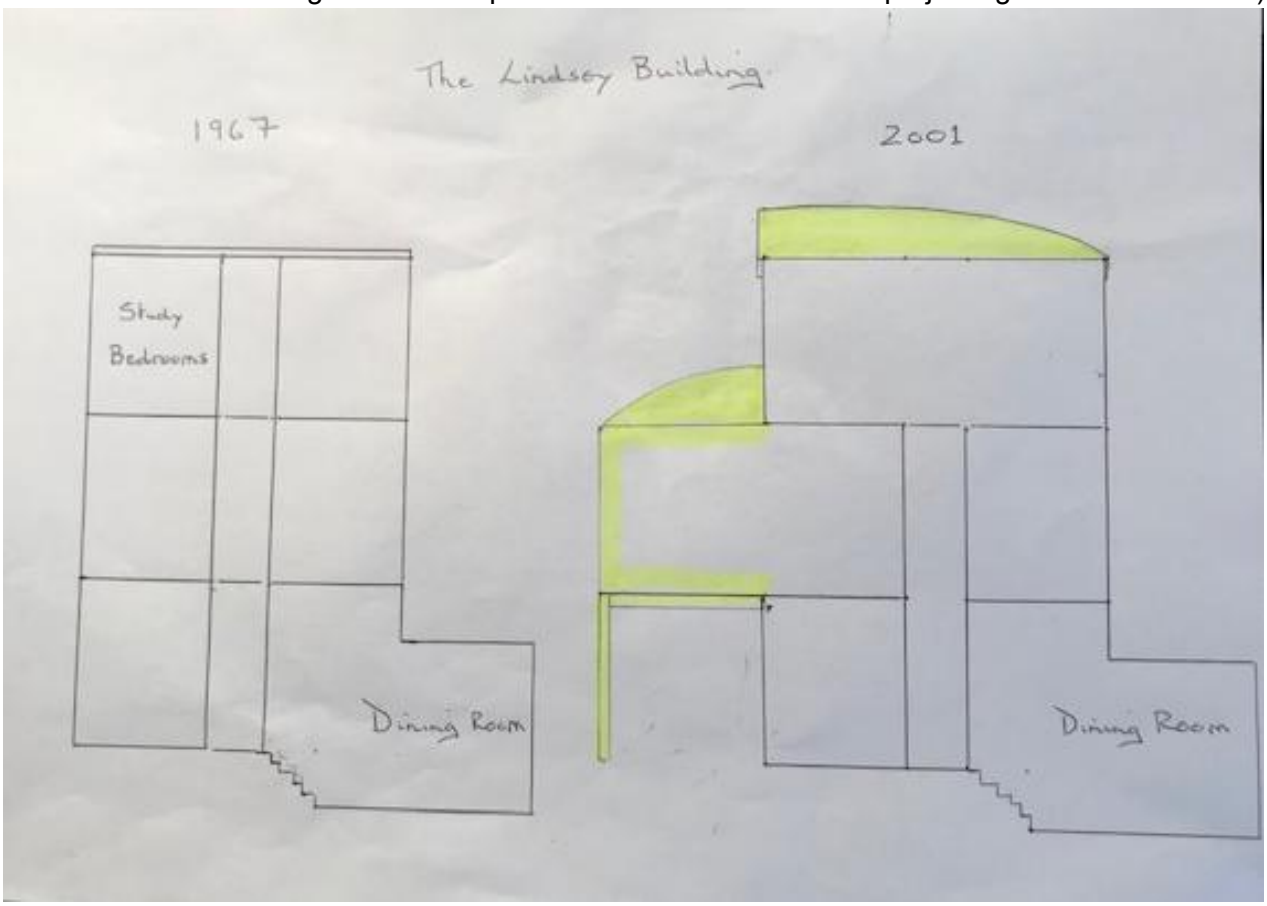
With the School successfully avoiding closure in 1960 and the demand for boarding expanding a new boarding house, Lindsey House, was opened in 1967 at the bottom of the Terraces.



This brutalist, flat roofed building housed a new dining room, students study bedrooms and a matron’s flat as well as accommodation for boarding masters and mistresses.



When boarding at the school ended in 1995 Lindsey House was largely unused other than the dining room and art moving into the converted Matron's flat. Music also moved into the ground floor rooms and a flat was retained for French and German language guests to use while working for CGS.
The problem was how to convert the rest of Lindsey House due to the limitations created by how the building was constructed. (Note the central corridor in the 1967 sketch – a structural feature – and flat roof and then how the building was changed in 2001 (see yellow sections in the sketch below) – the half barrel roof, removal of corridor on top floor as not structural for the roof – so four classrooms could be created for English on the top floor. – two classrooms built projecting from the first floor)



The conversion was carried out in 2001 after a successful grant application. This shows the two maths rooms projecting from the first floor on the eastern side of the building.



Leaving a covered walkway beneath.



This shows the Lindsey building and the hard surfaced middle court built to make more use of the flat area at the bottom of the Terraces. Pupil numbers were rising from 500+ to 600+ with particular growth in the 6th form numbers.
The wonderful redwood tree was recently cut down due to safety concerns.





This panoramic view, by Steven Millington, shows the massive marquee erected on middle court.





The marquee was constructed to give more covered space during the Covid pandemic.



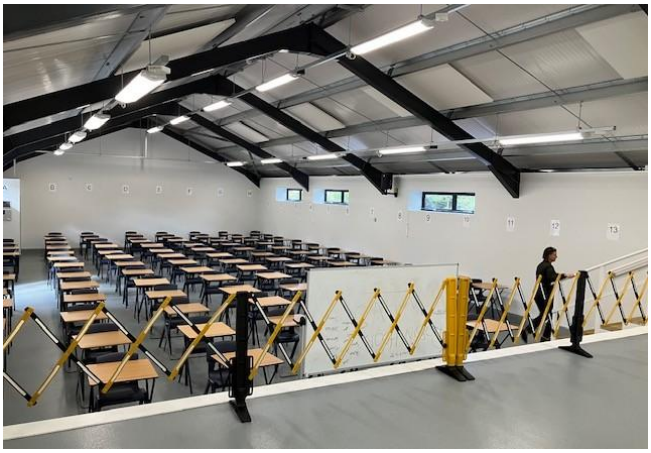
In the mid 1960s Keith Flunder, Head of Maths for many years, was the driving force in the successful construction of a swimming pool on the School site below the line of the Roman wall.



I don’t think it has ever been an attractive building but it served a purpose until the pool developed cracks. It was left unused for a few years until we gained a grant to complete a basic conversion into a hall, for exams, meetings and various activities like dance and drama. It was rather grandly called the New Hall. Recently this building has been completely rebuilt and renamed The Newbolt Centre.

The Newbolt Centre constructed on the site of the old swimming pool/New Hall.





This shows the interior of the Newbolt Centre.

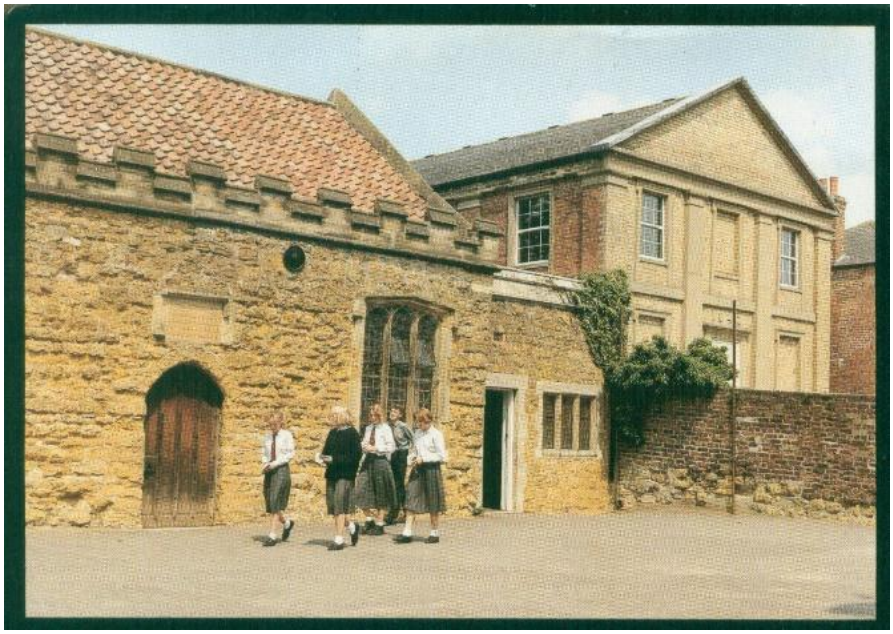


We think that Beech House at the bottom of the School by the North Kelsey Road entrance was acquired around the mid 1960s, when the Head, Mr Michel, moved from living in the southern end of Casterby House to Beech House.



Mr Michel, the Head until 1981 and Mr Foulkes, Head from 1981 to 1995 lived here but on Trevor Foulkes' retirement it became the Site Manager's home until recently. In the last few years it has been converted into Office accommodation and been used for staff and student use.

The School had used the 1842 Congregational chapel during the late 50s, 60s and 70s.





But then in 1983 the Congregational Chapel was converted into the School's Library.



As well as the library it now houses a computer suite and the prop store for the School's productions. Senior Teacher and twice Mayor of Caistor, Philip Ashley-Smith, in the late 1980s and 90s kept the props in the old telephone exchange which the School owned until the late 1990s when it was sold to Varlows the builders.



The new Manning building and a science extension to the Main building was opened in 1984.

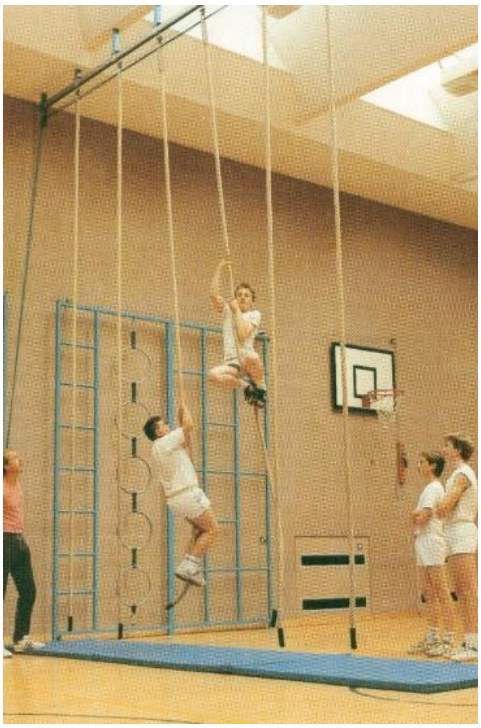




The Manning building filled the space between Casterby House (left) and Grove House and Room 19 (right). The sash windows in Casterby are ‘Caistor windows’.

The period of construction was very disruptive with reliance again on portacabins constructed in





available spaces. The Manning building provided 4 classrooms and a gym and changing rooms.



The Old Hall was no longer needed as a gym!



Unfortunately it was another flat roofed building.

In 2005 when CGS became a Sports College as well as being a grammar school, the Manning building was remodelled, creating a fitness suite and PE classroom/computer room as well as extending Manning towards the Terraces by building two new classrooms with an undercroft beneath.



Going back to the early 1990s CGS began work on two new Technology blocks which also had a new biology lab. In 1993 the first block was opened with a bridge going over the line of the Roman wall and joining the building at first floor height. There had been an extensive archaeological dig with concrete rafts being built covering the Roman site prior to the Tech blocks being built.



It was at the back of the 1930 Main building with the 1984 Science extension. The photo shows the old girls' toilets and the west end of the original 1630 building.



The second block opened in 1994, and, as I understand it, to avoid paying VAT the two blocks couldn't be joined for 10 years. In 2004 when a bridge was costed it was felt the £50,000 to build one could be put to much better use.



In 2011 it looked as though Food Technology was going to be made a compulsory subject by the government. As CGS had no facilities a grant was awarded to remodel the southern end of the Lindsey building.



A Food Technology room was built and music facilities were extended too.



Going back to the 1930s the Terraces were grass and Beech House was a private residence.



By 2013 the School had over 650 students and the Olympic Torch building had been squeezed in between Lindsey House and Beech House.

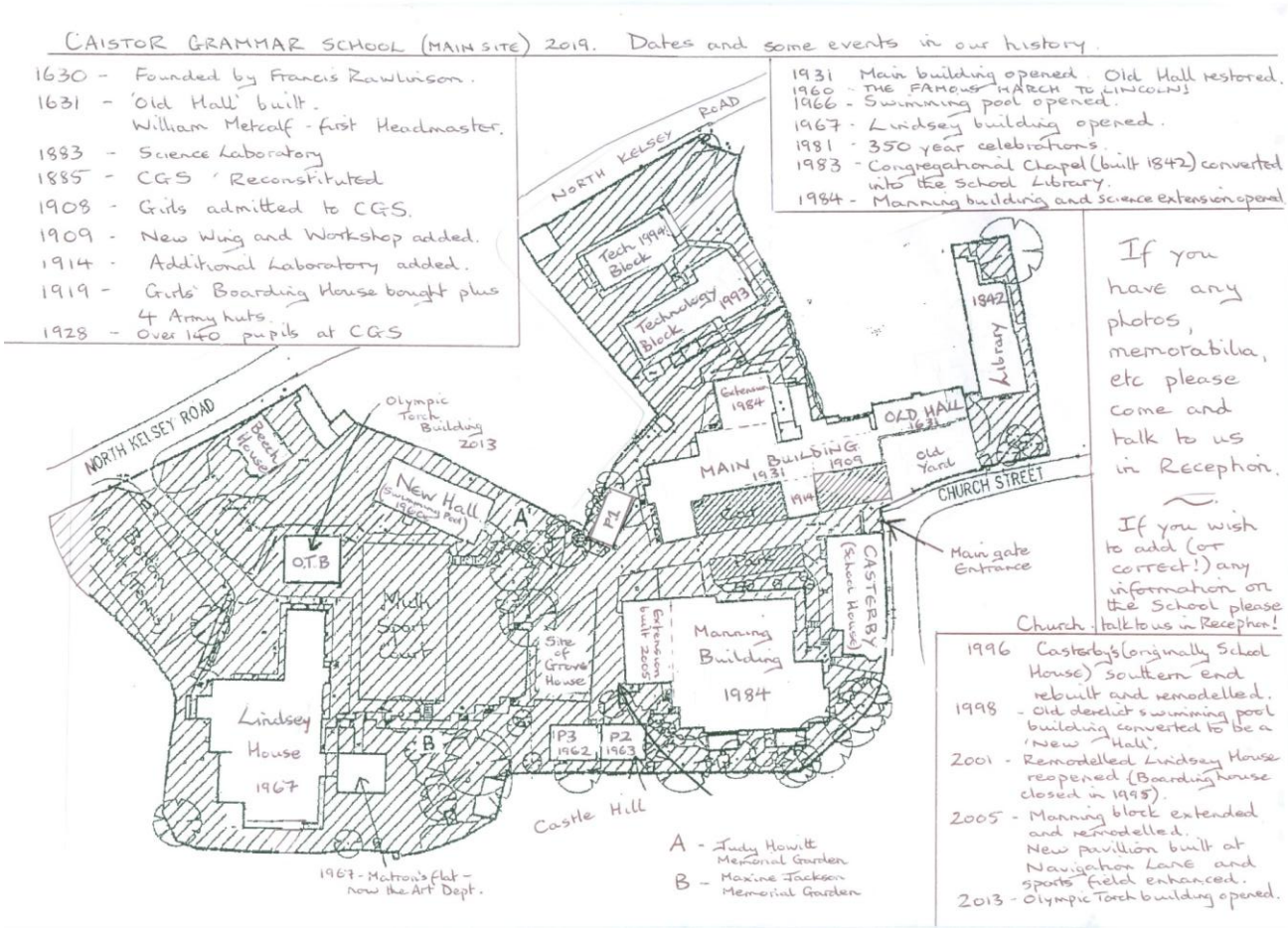


It was named after the School students involvement in the 2012 Olympics.

It is more attractive from the front, facing down North Kelsey Road.



This map was produced for a Reunion at School in 2019. It has a few inaccuracies but it gives a reasonable summary of what was built when.



One building I haven’t mentioned and remains a bit of a mystery is the current site manager and his team’s workshop. Was it a folly or an outbuilding for Grove House?



When I first saw it I thought it used to be a chapel but the West Lindsey conservation officer thought the windows had probably been reused from another derelict building in Caistor.



And just behind the workshop which also, by the way, has a false garage door on Castle Hill, is, we believe, the pig sty that Headmaster Coxon had built and used in the 1920s and 30s.



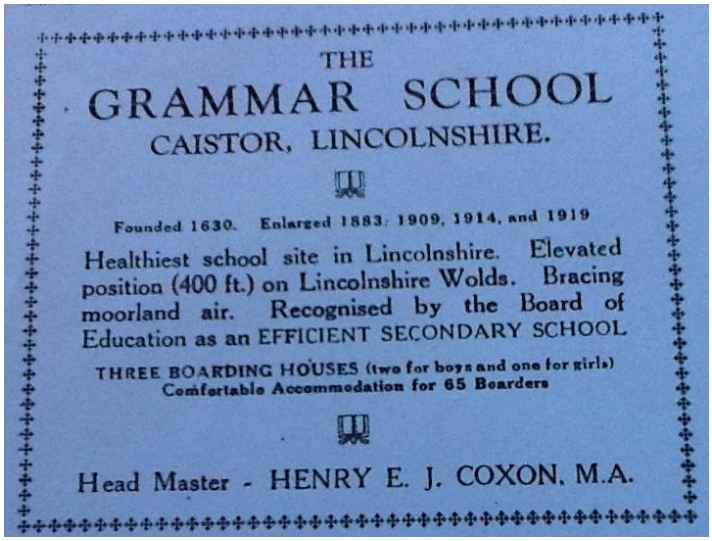
And finally another relatively new building. Grove Court is a 3 classroom languages block built on the bottom tennis and netball court site which led to the removal of the 3 remaining portacabins, two of which will have served the school for about 60 years.



The new languages block with Beech House in the background.

Boarding at CGS by Graeme Kemshall

		BOARDERS FLOWCHART 1630 TO 1913		
1630		**FORMATION**		
				13/14 HEADMASTERS
				NO RECORD OF
				BOARDING
1770 - 1802		**GROVE**		
CHRISTOPHER CAVE		**HOUSE**		
				SOLD 1805
				SCHOOL FOR YOUNG LADIES
				TWO HEADMASTERS
1838 - 1853		**ADVERT FOR**		
WILLIAM ELLIS		**BOARDING ARRANGEMENTS**		
1853 - 1884		**GROVE**		**REBOUGHT AND**
ANTHONY BOWER		**HOUSE**		**ENLARGED**
				THREE HEADMASTERS
1904 - 1913		**NETTLETON**		**HIRED AT BROOKE'S**
ARTHUR BROOKE		**RECTORY**		**EXPENSE**
1913 - 1945				
H E J COXON				



			BOARDERS FLOWCHART 1913 TO 1995	
1913 - 1945		1914	1919	1921
H.E.J.COXON		SCHOOL	GROVE	RED
		HOUSE	HOUSE	HOUSE
				REMOVED
1945 - 1957		BOYS	GIRLS	
R CAPPER		BOARDING	BOARDING	
		HOUSE	HOUSE	
1957 - 1981				
K.G.MICHEL				
	1960	PROPOSED SCHOOL CLOSURE		
	1967 - MAY			LINDSEY
				HOUSE
	1967 - SEPTEMBER	CASTERBY	6TH	MIXED
		JUNIOR	FORM	BOARDERS
		GIRLS	CENTRE	
	1969	JUNIOR	6TH	MIXED
		GIRLS	FORM	BOARDERS
			GIRLS	
	1978	MIXED	6TH	MIXED
		JUNIORS	FORM	BOARDERS
			GIRLS	
1981 - 1996				
T FOULKES				
	1987 - JANUARY	INSPECTION		
	1987 - EASTER	MIXED JNRS	EVACUATION	MIXED BDRS
		3RD YR GIRLS		6TH FORM
				GIRLS
	1987 - SEPTEMBER	MIXED		MIXED
		6TH FORM		OTHERS
			DEMOLITION	
	1994 / 1995	END OF BOARDING		
	LATER	6TH FORM		CLASSROOMS
		CENTRE		ETC

The Curriculum by Polly Baxter.

So far, we have covered the history of Caistor Grammar School in terms of its foundation status and its struggles for viability, and we've covered its various building developments and the special contribution of its Boarding element.

I want now to turn to the school's functioning as a place of learning.

- What did the curriculum look like?
- What changes have been made over the years?
- And what influenced those changes?

When Caistor Grammar School opened in 1631, the curriculum was very similar to that of other grammar schools – it consisted of the Classics, both Latin and Greek, Religious Studies, and Reading – mostly from the Bible and the Book of Common Prayer - plus English Grammar, which was taught as it related to Latin Grammar – hence the term 'Grammar School'.
The will of William Hansard had requested that in addition to these subjects, 'good' literature should be taught at CGS, so it is likely that scholars also studied the works of popular writers such as John Milton and John Donne.

Even so, as you can imagine, this was still a very narrow, academic curriculum, and the teaching and learning styles would also have been rather uninspiring with much chanting of Latin texts and rote learning.
Moreover, in those early days, there would have been a parental expectation that the school would take care of its pupils' moral development, and at the time, there would have been quite a lot of state and church censorship to support the school in this role. We know this from a comment by Comenius, a well-known philosopher and educator of the time, who observed:

"Lewd, superstitious books, and ballads were censored, as were all filthy places in the poets."

Unsurprisingly, not all Caistor parents were happy with this narrow curriculum and in the early 1800s, a group of Caistor parents made it clear to the school, that there was **too much religion** in the curriculum; they objected specifically to the 2 hours on Saturday afternoons devoted to learning the Catechism and the "construing of chapters in the Greek or Latin Testament".
In contrast, other parents were quite content with this situation, because, as many of you will know, a good number of Caistor residents throughout history have always been staunchly committed to their religious faith.
Also, let's not forget, that CGS **is** physically close to the church of St Peter and St Paul and seems always to have been actively involved in its life. Add to this, the great influence of the non-conformist movement in the 19th Century, with 3 new chapels being built in Caistor, and we can see that many parents would have approved of the high religious content of the curriculum.

Let's look now at other influences on the school's curriculum:

From a simple glance at important World Events, we can see that Experiment, Travel and Discovery were bold features of the UK's development as an industrialised economy, and such activities were bound to have an impact on the school curriculum – for no school can exist in a vacuum.

For example, it is easy to see how Geography became a curriculum subject when we consider the impact of Sir Walter Raleigh's 1585 discovery of the New World, and the Pilgrim Fathers' sailing to America in 1620. Add to these kinds of events, the on-going expansion of the British Empire and the development of commercialism, and the school curriculum, as described hitherto, begins to seem quite unfit for purpose.
Correspondingly, the universities were leading the way in the 18th Century with the development of degree courses in such subjects as science, medicine, mathematics, astronomy and languages.

So, how did CGS respond to the changing needs of scholars?

We have a copy of a pupil recruitment advertisement which appeared in the Stamford Mercury in 1838. Attempting to entice parents to send their boys to CGS, the HT declares that the curriculum at CGS was:
"such as to qualify young gentlemen for either of the Universities or for entering upon any scientific or practical pursuit. In addition to the usual branches of scholastic education, the elements of Natural Philosophy, Natural History and Chemistry are taught practically by experiments performed by the pupils themselves. To those intended for agricultural pursuits the application of Chemistry to Agriculture will also be taught. The strictest attention is paid to the religious and moral training of the pupils and to the propriety and decorum of their habits and conversation ….

So, we can begin to see that throughout the 18th and 19th centuries, the curriculum at CGS was indeed adapting to a more modern world outside of the school gates.

Now we come to the influence of Central Government on the content of the school curriculum. During the Industrial Revolution, the need for a literate and educated working population began to dawn on the government of the day.
The result was, that between 1880 and1944, free compulsory primary and secondary schools were gradually introduced, these to be administered by Local Authorities.

For CGS this meant increased funding from Lindsey Education Authority, towards the provision of:

- A free grammar school education for both girls and boys, up to the age of 15
- An 11+ entrance exam set and administered by the LEA
- A small kindergarten (in existence from 1893 to 1944)
- and later, the possibility of cooperation with CYS (which had opened in 1938) through use of its facilities for Woodwork and Needlework.

Central government also began to turn its attention to a national examination system:

and between 1918 &1951 the School Certificate and Higher School Certificate were in place. These were subject-based exams with grades at Distinction, Credit, Pass or Fail. In order to 'matriculate' with the School Cert, students had to gain 5 passes including: English, maths, science, a foreign language and one other subject.
Such a system had a great impact on the content of the curriculum and upon the teaching and learning styles of secondary schools. There was much teaching to the test. There may be people in this room who remember it well? Incredibly, such a system still operates in some parts of the old British Empire.

By 1951 GCE O' levels and A' levels had been introduced, again subject-based with grades
These were followed in 1965 by the introduction of:

- CSE, or Certificate of Secondary Education, intended for less academic students and in
- 1986 by GCSE which replaced both O' levels and CSE, with grades from A to G

After this, the great 1988 Education Reform Act swept in with a National Curriculum and a National Assessment System for all schools in England. Much of this is still in place, as is the GCSE examination.

<u>Uncertain Times</u>
Throughout much of this time, the future of CGS was extremely uncertain.
In 1960 and again by the mid 1980s, CGS (and later CYS) were considered too small to be viable, especially in terms of the breadth of the curriculum on offer.
The LEA was pushing for a Caistor Comprehensive school, which as you can imagine was an idea that met with much resistance.
So what could be done?

In 1984, the 2 respective Headteachers of the secondary schools, Trevor Foulkes and Barry Tointon, came up with a scheme, known as Plan 4B. This extended the existing cooperation between CGS and CYS through joint sports teams and trips, by requiring some teachers to work in both schools, and by merging some exam classes for pupils in English, Maths, Geography, Languages and practical subjects. In this way, curriculum options were broadened for more students at 14, without additional expense for either school.
This plan was accepted by the LEA and was popular with pupils, but difficult to manage in terms of timetabling. It lasted for only a short time. Fortuitously, for both schools, other central government legislation was working in Caistor's favour.

Between 1980 and 1988 several Education Acts encouraged parental choice of school and allowed children to cross county boundaries. The result was that pupil numbers increased in both schools and 4B was no longer considered necessary.
From this point on, CGS went from strength to strength.

The reforms of the 1988 Education Act brought increasing independence from the LA with Grant Maintained status for the school,and later Specialist School Status for Humanities and Sport. Both initiatives brought additional funding - a new pavilion was built as well as new specialist teaching accommodation. Academy status in 2010 during Roger Hales' time as HT, also increased the school's capacity to provide a broad and balanced curriculum relevant to its pupils' needs.

Yet, it would not be fair to leave you with the impression that extra funding, new buildings and an appropriate curriculum are all that is required to make a good school.
A successful school is the sum of many parts and here we must include mention of the very strong and far-ranging extra curricular programme at CGS which has always made an enormous contribution to the experience and achievements of students, as also has, what is known as the 'hidden curriculum', i.e. the values and ideals fostered by the school.

In the 21st century the school has achieved many accolades:

- It has been judged to be an 'Outstanding School' in all 4 of its Ofsted Reports
- More than once it has been ranked top school in Lincolnshire for its GCSE and A' level results
- And more than once it has been ranked as Top state school in the East Midlands

The mission statement illustrates the intentions of all who work in the school:
It reads as follows:
"Caistor Grammar School is a learning community where we work hard to enable our students to make the most of their ability, to be happy and to be fulfilled.
We help our students gain an enviable academic education, to learn practical skills and to develop their powers to reason. Learning, for us, goes beyond examination results.
We promote learning to foster an understanding of the other aspects of life: social, moral, spiritual, aesthetic and physical."

I think you will agree the school has much to offer and much to celebrate.

Conclusion
And so we come to the end of our account of the history of Caistor Grammar School.

Thank you for you for giving us the opportunity to share it with you. It's been rather a whistle stop tour, to cover such a complex history, but I hope it leaves you a little more informed.

I'm sure that you would like to join us in wishing Caistor Grammar School continuing success in the next 400 years.